

Rhea^o wrapped a huge stone in a baby's robe, and fed it
to Ouranos' wide-ruling son, king of the earlier gods; 485
he took it in his hands and put it down his belly,
the fool; he did not think in his mind that instead
of a stone his own son, undefeated and secure, was left
behind, soon to overthrow him by force and violence and 490
drive him from his honor, and rule the immortals himself.

Swiftly then^o the strength and noble limbs
of the future lord grew; at the end of a year,
tricked by the clever advice of Gaia,^o
great crafty Kronos threw up his children, 495
defeated by the craft and force of his own son.
First he vomited out the stone^o he had swallowed last;
Zeus fixed it firmly in the wide-pathed earth
at sacred Pytho in the vales of Parnassos,
to be a sign thereafter, a wonder to mortal men. 500

He released from their deadly chains his uncles,^o
Ouranos' sons, whom their father mindlessly bound.
They did not forget gratitude for his help,

485-488 The trick of Rhea may have a parallel in the myth of Kumarbi, who, with three gods already inside him, asks for a "son" (or a "stone") to eat; unfortunately the text here (column ii 39-54, *ANET* 121) is so badly preserved that it can scarcely be read at all. According to Pausanias, a local Arcadian legend said that Rhea had earlier hidden Poseidon among lambs and given Kronos a foal to swallow instead of Poseidon (8.8), and several places (e.g., Mount Thaumasio in Arcadia, 8.36; Mount Petrachos in Boiotia, 9.41) were claimed by local inhabitants to be the place where Rhea gave Kronos the stone to swallow.

492-493 It seems to take a year for Zeus to grow up; the length of time may reflect the role of the Minoan year-god.

494-496 "Clever advice of Gaia" may be what she told Rhea, or may now tell Zeus. Apollodoros (1.2.1) says Metis assisted Zeus by giving Kronos an emetic drug.

497-500 The stone disgorged by Kronos was exhibited at Delphi (Pytho), where Pausanias saw it (10.24). Parnassos is the mountain of Delphi, and Pytho, at first the general area around Delphi, became an alternate name for Delphi itself. There was a more famous stone at Delphi, the *omphalos* [navel-stone] which marked Delphi as the center of the earth. Pausanias (10.16) distinguishes the *omphalos* from the stone of Kronos, but Pausanias is almost 900 years later than Hesiod, who perhaps identifies the two.

501-506 The "uncles" (501) must be the Kyklopes, who were imprisoned in Tartaros by Ouranos and who will give Zeus the lightning (504-505); the freeing of their brothers, the Hundred-Handed, will be reported in 617-626. The Greek text is ambivalent on whether the "father" in 502 is Ouranos or Kronos; Hesiod must have meant Ouranos, but Apollodoros says that Kronos released the Kyklopes and Hundred-Handed at the time of Ouranos' castration and then imprisoned them again in Tartaros (1.1.4-5).

and gave him thunder and the fiery lightning-bolt
and lightning, which vast Gaia earlier had hidden; 505
relying on these, he is king of mortals and immortals.

Iapetos married the fine-ankled daughter of Okeanos,
Klymene, and went up to the same bed;^o
she bore him a son, strong-hearted Atlas,^o and
she bore all-eminent Menoitios, and Prometheus^o 510
subtle and devious, and wrong-thinking Epimetheus,^o
who was from the first an evil for men who work for food;^o
he first received from Zeus the molded^o woman,
the virgin. Wide-seeing Zeus sent arrogant Menoitios^o
down to Erebos, striking him with a smoking thunderbolt, 515
for his recklessness and excessive pride.
And Atlas,^o standing at the limits of the earth,

507-508 After hinting at Zeus' inevitable victory (506), Hesiod interrupts the story of conflict between Zeus and his father to introduce the conflict between Zeus and Prometheus. First, however, he must finish the account of the genealogy of the Titans; Iapetos, the one remaining Titan son, will be the father of Prometheus. Klymene is the Okeanid of 351.

509 Atlas, the eldest of Iapetos' four sons, is the giant who holds up the sky (519).

510 Menoitios appears elsewhere only in *Ap* 1.2.3, where he is said to have been thunder-bolted to Tartaros during the Titanomachy. Prometheus' name was interpreted by the Greeks to mean "Forethought," but the linguistic derivation is unclear. Some Sanskritists associate Prometheus with the Sanskrit verb *manth*, whose primary meaning is "vigorous backwards and forwards motion of any sort;" it refers especially to the production of fire from fire-sticks, sexual activity, stealing (particularly the theft of ambrosia or fire), churning (see on 188-199), and it is related to the name Mandara (the Indian mountain used for churning ambrosia/semen). The name Prometheus might also be related to the Hindu culture-hero Prthu, who steals the cow of immortality from the gods to help a mortal and is the founder of the civilizing arts.

511 Epimetheus [Afterthought] is the husband of Pandora and father of Pyrrha, who marries Prometheus' son Deukalion (*Ap* 1.7.2). Deukalion and Pyrrha are the Greek version of the Biblical Noah and his wife.

512 An allusion to Epimetheus' folly in accepting Pandora from Zeus, as described in the following two lines.

513 Pandora is "molded," because she is made from earth by Hephaistos (571-572).

514-516 The only stated offense of the "arrogant" Menoitios is his "recklessness and excessive pride," which must put him in the category of gigantic figures (e.g., Typhoeus, the Giants, the Aloidai) who try to usurp Zeus' position.

517-520 In the *Odyssey* (1.52-54) Atlas is the father of Kalypso and holds up the pillars which separate earth and sky. In 746-748 Atlas will be situated somewhere in the underworld, but here he is placed with the Hesperides in their garden in the far west. This may not be a contradiction; the location of the underworld in archaic Greek literature is notoriously elusive, and appears in the *Theogony* as both under

before the clear-voiced Hesperides, under strong compulsion,
holds the wide sky with head and untiring arms;
or this is the fate wise Zeus allotted him. 520
He bound devious Prometheus^o with inescapable
harsh bonds, fastened through the middle of a column,
and he inflicted on him a long-winged eagle, which ate
his immortal liver; but it grew as much in all
at night as the long-winged bird would eat all day. 525
Herakles,^o the mighty son of fine-ankled Alkmene,
killed it and freed from evil suffering the son
of Iapetos and released him from anguish
by the will of high-ruling Olympian Zeus,

the earth and at the ends of the earth. The sky-holding is evidently a punishment, since Atlas is "under strong compulsion," but the reason for his punishment is even less clear than in the case of Menoitios. If we exclude Epimetheus, who functions as a mortal rather than as a god (West, *T* 309-310), we are left with three similar brothers, a "decomposition" or splitting into three versions of the figure of a rebellious giant who is punished.

521-525 Although the scene of Prometheus' punishment is said in almost all accounts to be the Caucasus Mountains (or Skythia, which may be the same), there seems to be another version in which he, like Atlas, is at the western ends of the earth. This is the site of the garden of the Hesperides, and it is during Herakles' search for this garden that he encounters Prometheus. The most famous version of Prometheus' punishment, Aeschylus' *Prometheus Bound*, is set in Skythia (2), but in the lower margin of the ancient Hypothesis to this play the following note appears: "Prometheus is not bound in the Caucasus as in the usual story but at the European limits of the ocean, as can be seen from the words spoken to Io." Aeschylus also calls Prometheus the son of Themis (18), and an Aeschylean fragment has the eagle visit Prometheus every other day. The focus of the eagle's attention is Prometheus' liver, because the liver was associated with passion and erotic striving at least as early as Aeschylus; the punishment is a kind of castration, since the offense of Prometheus is an oedipal crime (see *Ps* 92-94). West (*T* 313-314) objects to this significance of the liver since it is not stated explicitly before the 5th century, but it is surely implicit in the punishment of Tityos in the *Odyssey* (11.576-579). Tityos is bound while two vultures devour his liver, and the similarity of the punishments inflicted on Tityos and Prometheus would suggest that the meanings of their crimes are also similar.

526-534 Herakles, the greatest hero of Greek myth, is the son of Zeus and Alkmene. He is usually said to have released Prometheus during his eleventh labor (the golden apples of the Hesperides). There may seem to be a contradiction between this account of Herakles' killing the eagle and freeing Prometheus "from evil suffering" and the later statement that "great bondage holds" Prometheus (616). West (*T* 313) takes the present tense of "holds" too literally and solves the contradiction by having Herakles kill the eagle but leave Prometheus still chained. This is possible but unlikely; Zeus is said to have ended his anger (533), and the present tense "holds" occurs in a moralizing coda finishing the story with a general principle.

so that the glory of Theban-born Herakles 530
would be more than before on the nurturing earth;
thinking of this, he honored his famous son, and
though he was angry quit the rage he had ever since
the Titan matched wits with Kronos' mighty son.
For when gods and mortal men made a settlement^o 535
at Mekone,^o then he cleverly cut up a big ox and
set it before them, trying to deceive the mind of Zeus.
For Zeus he set out meat and innards rich with fat
on the skin, covering it with the stomach of the ox;
but for men he set the white ox-bones,^o with crafty skill 540
arranging them well and covering them with shining fat.

535-564 The account of the deceptive banquet at Mekone is, on one level, an explanation of why, in Greek blood sacrifice, the bones of the sacrificed animal are given to the gods while the flesh is kept for humans to eat. Human sacrificers could justify this distribution by referring to the choice Zeus had made (knowingly, according to Hesiod) at Mekone. On another level, it is an example of a repeated motif in the Prometheus myth, his deception of Zeus and the appropriation of Zeus' prerogative. This motif appears again in the theft of fire (565-566) and in various later stories (e.g., that Prometheus, when creating mankind, was supposed to present his work to Zeus for approval, but kept back and hid Phainon, the handsomest boy). On this second level, the banquet at Mekone is parallel to the banquet of Tantalos, who tried to deceive Zeus by serving him his chopped-up son Pelops at a meal (Pindar, *Olympian* 1). The myths of Tantalos and Prometheus are in several ways doubles of one another: a) at a communal meal each of them conceals something beneath the surface of food in an ambiguously successful attempt to deceive Zeus; b) each of them steals a prerogative of Zeus which mortals are forbidden to possess, Prometheus fire and Tantalos ambrosia (which are symbolically and structurally equivalent); c) each of them is punished by Zeus, Tantalos in Tartaros and Prometheus in a fashion almost exactly the same as Tantalos' fellow-sufferer Tityos. For a discussion of this comparison see *Ps* 92-94.

535-536 The meeting between men and gods at Mekone marks the end of the time when men and gods lived and ate together; the period before their separation may be the time of Hesiod's Golden Race (*WD* 109-126). The banquet of Tantalos, as well as his theft of ambrosia, must also take place at a time when men and gods have not yet been finally separated. Mekone is the old name for Sikyon, a city near Corinth in the north-east Peloponnese.

540-541 The skillful arrangement of the bones may express the care Prometheus took to conceal his trick from Zeus. But it may reflect the wide-spread care given to the arrangement of bones in primitive sacrificial cults, a concern based on the hope that the dead animal will come to life again. In a Magyar myth cited by Frazer (*Spirits of the Corn and of the Wild* [London 1890], vol. 2, p. 263), a hero is cut into pieces; the serpent-king lays the bones together in their proper order and washes them; the hero comes to life, but his shoulder blade has been lost, so he is given a substitute of gold and ivory. In the myth of Tantalos' banquet, his son Pelops is restored to life and given an ivory shoulder to replace the shoulder Demeter had eaten.

Then the father of men and gods said to him:

"Son of Iapetos, distinguished of all gods,
sir, how unjustly you divided the portions."

544

Thus Zeus, knowing deathless plans, spoke and mocked him.

But clever Prometheus answered him, gently
smiling, and did not forget his crafty trick:

"Zeus, most honored and greatest of eternal gods,
take of these whichever the spirit within tells you."

He spoke with the trick in mind; but Zeus, knowing deathless
plans, knew and did not miss the trick; in his heart
he foresaw evils which were going to happen to mortal men.

550

With both hands he lifted up the white fat,
but he was angry in mind and rage came to his spirit,
when he saw the white ox-bones in the crafty trick.

555

Therefore the tribes of men on earth burn to the
immortals white bones on reeking altars.

Greatly angry, cloud-gatherer Zeus said to him:

"Son of Iapetos, knowing thoughts beyond all,
sir, you still have not forgotten your crafty trick."

560

So spoke angry Zeus, who knows deathless plans;
from then on, never forgetting the trick, he would
not give the strength of untiring fire to ash-trees
for mortal men, who live on the earth."

543-544 An ironic statement, if Zeus really recognizes the trick of Prometheus (551).

550-551 "It has long been recognized that in the original story Zeus did not see through the trick and was thoroughly deceived" (West, *T* 321). Hesiod's version is an attempt to rescue Zeus, the hero of his poem, from the appearance of being duped.

552 The "evils" are the withholding of fire and the creation of Pandora.

558-559 These lines will be repeated almost exactly in *WD* 53-54.

562-564 It is unclear whether men had fire before and Zeus now deprives them of it, or if they had never possessed it. The reference to "ash-trees" (563) may refer to a belief that originally fire was present within trees (West, *T* 325); such a belief no doubt goes back to a time when fire was procured from lightning-struck trees. Alternatively, the word "ash-trees" [*melieisi*] may be an adjective with "mortal men"; in *WD* 143-145 the men of the Bronze Race are made from ash-trees [*melian*], and the phrase in the *Theogony* may mean "early men."

565-567 Myths of the theft of fire are found among primitive cultures on every inhabited continent. Sometimes the thief is a culture-hero like Prometheus, but typically it is an animal, most often a bird or insect (because of their ability to fly from earth to sky and back); an interesting collection of these myths is in Frazer's *Apollo-dorus: The Library* (Harvard 1921), vol. 2, pp. 326-350. Because of the necessity of fire for many of the technical advances of civilization, the thief of fire may become a culture-hero like Prometheus, who is said by Aeschylus to have taught men

But the great son of Iapetos deceived him*

565

and stole the far-seen light of untiring fire
in a hollow narthex; this bit deep in the spirit
of high-thundering Zeus and his heart was angry
when he saw the far-seen light of fire among men.

In return for fire, he quickly made an evil for men;
for the famous Lame One made from earth the likeness

570

woodworking, astronomy, mathematics, the domestication of animals, navigation, medicine, prophecy, and metallurgy, in addition to giving them fire and "blind hopes" (*Prometheus Bound* 436-506). Indo-European myths contain a vast complex of stories in which fire or ambrosia is stolen from the gods and carried through the air to men; in Hindu myths, which contain the most extensive versions of this theft, fire and ambrosia are virtually interchangeable, and in Greek myth we have seen the close similarity between Prometheus (fire) and Tantalos (ambrosia). As the prerogative of the sky-god, fire ultimately represents his jealously-guarded sexual power, and the hero who steals it from him must pay for his crime with a symbolic castration. Thus the fire-god Hephaistos, defeated when he fights with Zeus on his mother's behalf, falls from sky to earth and is lamed as a result. Similarly, Frazer's collection (337-338) contains a myth of the Nigerian Ekoi in which the boy who steals fire from the Sky God is lamed as punishment; he is known only as "Lame Boy," just as Hephaistos is often referred to simply as the "Lame One" (e.g., *Th* 579). Even the animal versions contain symbolic castrations: the Karok Indians of California say that the frog originally had a tail, but lost it while stealing fire (343), and a similar story about how the deer lost its once-long tail is told by the Tlingit Indians of Alaska (348). On the psychology of the theft of fire see *Ps* 92-94.

567 A narthex is the giant fennel plant; its slowly combustible interior and hard rind make it an appropriate vessel in which to carry and conceal fire.

570-589 Zeus punishes men by ordering the creation and adornment of Pandora, the first woman. How men earlier reproduced themselves without women is not mentioned, but belief in some sort of asexual reproduction is not impossible. Myths told of men being born from stones (*Ap* 1.7.2) or from the earth, through the work of a craftsman god like Prometheus or Hephaistos; both Prometheus and Hephaistos are called the creators of Pandora, and Prometheus is said to have created men from earth and water (*Ap* 1.7.1) just as Hephaistos made Pandora (*WD* 60-61). Within a few centuries of Hesiod's time the first Greek philosophers were repeating these ideas in a new form of "scientific" speculation. For Anaximander, life began when water and earth were heated to a certain temperature; since this took place in the "moist," the first men during the helplessness of infancy were nurtured and reared within fish. In the 5th century Archelaus of Athens is supposed to have believed that at first men appeared from the earth, were nurtured on ooze, and only later began to reproduce. Empedokles said that "shoots of miserable men and women" were born "from the earth, having a portion both of water and heat," and Demokritos held that the first men were created from water and mud (these theories are discussed W. K. C. Guthrie, *In the Beginning* [Ithaca 1957] 32-38).

571-572 The "Lame One" is Hephaistos. These two lines are repeated almost exactly in *WD* 70-71; earlier in the latter poem Hephaistos is ordered by Zeus to make Pandora from earth and water (60-61).

of a modest virgin, by the plans of Kronos' son.
 Owl-eyed Athena sashed her and dressed her^o
 in silver clothes; she placed with her hands a
 decorated veil on her head, marvelous to see; 575
 [and lovely fresh garlands, the flowers of plants,
 Pallas Athene put around her head]^o
 and she placed on her head a golden crown
 which the famous Lame One had made himself,
 shaping it with his hands, to please father Zeus. 580
 On it he carved many designs, a marvelous sight;
 of all dread beasts the land and sea nourish,
 he included most, amazingly similar to living
 animals with voices; and beauty breathed over all.
 But when he made the lovely evil to pay for the good, 585
 he led her where the other gods and men were;^o
 she delighted in the finery from the great father's
 owl-eyed daughter; awe filled immortal gods and mortal
 men when they saw the sheer trick, irresistible to men.
 For from her is the race of female women,^o 590
 [from her is the deadly race and tribes of women]^o

573 This line reappears as WD 72. Athena and Hephaistos, the two gods most closely associated with crafts, are entrusted with the creation, dressing, and adornment of Pandora. In WD 60-82 a divine task force joins in this work, including Hephaistos (60), Athena (63), Aphrodite (65), Hermes (67), the Charites [Graces] and Peitho [Persuasion] (73), and the Horai [Seasons] (75). In addition to an elaborate adornment scene, the WD version adds other details not found in the *Theogony*: the name Pandora is given to the woman (who is unnamed in the *Theogony*) because all the gods "presented a gift" (82), which probably means that all the gods gave Pandora as a gift to men, not that each god gave her a separate gift; Pandora is received by Epimetheus, despite Prometheus' warning never to take a gift from Zeus (84-89); Pandora opens a jar and allows all evils and diseases to escape into the world, while retaining Elpis [Hope] within the jar (94-104); before Pandora and her jar men lived a paradisaal existence (90-92) like that of the Golden Race (109-120).

576-577 These lines are suspected by most editors because of the repetition of Athena's name in 573 and 577.

586 If before Pandora mankind lived in a Golden Age, this would explain why men and gods are together when Pandora is brought out for exhibition (see on 535-536).

590-601 The *Theogony* version is much more misogynistic than the WD version. In the latter the evils come from the jar which Pandora unfortunately opens, but here it is woman herself who is a great evil to man. This evil, it turns out, is the old-age complaint (of envious men) that women are idle consumers of the wealth a man has worked hard to amass.

591 Since 590 and 591 are alternate expressions, one of the lines is presumably not genuine.

a great plague to mortals, dwelling with men,
 not suited for cursed Poverty, but for Wealth.^o
 As when bees in covered hives feed^o
 the drones, companions of evil works, 595
 the bees work until sunset, all day
 and every day, and make the pale combs,
 while the drones stay inside, in the covered hives,
 reaping the work of others into their own stomachs;
 similarly for mortal men, high-thundering Zeus 600
 made an evil: women, the partners of evil works.
 He gave a second evil to balance a good,^o
 since whoever escapes marriage and women's harm,
 by refusing to marry, comes to deadly old age
 with no son to tend him; not lacking livelihood 605
 while he lives, when he dies distant kin divide
 his estate. But^o even the man whose fate is to marry
 and acquires a good wife, suited to his wants,
 for him from the first good and evil are balanced
 always; but whoever acquires the wicked sort 610
 lives with unending trouble in his mind and
 spirit and heart, and the evil is incurable.
 So it is impossible to cheat or surpass the mind of Zeus.
 For not even Iapetos' son, good Prometheus,
 escaped his heavy anger, but of necessity 615
 great bondage holds him, though he knows many things.^o

593 Poverty [Penia] and Wealth [Koros] are personified; they have no role in myth, although Plato makes Penia the mother of Eros (*Symposium* 203b).

594-601 A bee and drone simile recurs in WD 303-306, where a man who does not work is compared to the idle drones:

Gods and men are angry at a man who lives
 without work, behaving like the stingless drones
 who waste the bees' labor, not working but eating

602-607 The "second evil" (602) is lack of a son (605), and the "good" (602) is managing to escape marriage and to live alone. If someone avoids the first evil (woman) by remaining single, he will receive the second evil from Zeus, the absence of a son to take care of him in his old age and maintain his estate after he has died.

607-612 It is impossible, even for the man who manages to find a good wife, to have unmixed happiness, but the man who marries a bad wife will have unmixed misery. Why will the man with a good wife have evil as well as good? This may refer to the evils and diseases released from Pandora's jar in the WD, but it may also mean that even the good wife is not altogether good (see *Ps* 103).

616 For the apparent discrepancy between Prometheus' present bondage and his earlier liberation by Herakles, see on 526-534.

HESIOD'S THEOGONY

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